

RUINSTARS

Squad Operations In A Dying Galaxy

CORE RULES

Version 20251228





RUINSTARS

1. INTRODUCTION

THE GALAXY IS IN RUINS

The stars are dying, the gods are silent, and the empires that once ruled the galaxy have crumbled into ash and echoes.

Across a fractured void of decaying worlds and haunted relics, scattered fireteams carry out the final orders of long-dead masters.

There is no hope of victory - only duty and the bitter certainty that each mission may be the last.

In the shadows of ancient horrors and cursed machines, elite squads wage desperate black ops in a war that has lost all meaning... but not all purpose.

Welcome to Ruinstars - where only ruins remain, and only war endures.

WHAT IS THIS GAME?

Ruinstars is a squad-scale sci-fi skirmish wargame about doomed squads, impossible missions, and the brutal choices that decide who gets to walk away.

The stars are dying. The empires are ash. Your Squad is what remains.

Fast, lethal, objective-driven skirmishes with campaign persistence, built for PvP, solo, and co-op play.

- **Squad-Scale Tactics:** Command 4-10 Units in tight, terrain-heavy fights where positioning and timing matter more than raw stats.
- **Lethal & Decisive:** Units don't sponge damage. Mistakes get punished. Victories are earned.
- **Mission First:** Ruinstars is built around objectives, not just body counts. Every game is a mission with a clear payoff and consequences.
- **Narrative Without the Bloat:** Campaign play adds scars, rewards, and hard choices, without turning your table into bookkeeping.
- **Play How You Like:** Designed for head-to-head, solo, or co-op using NPC behaviors, campaign and operation structure, and Horde Mode.

NOTE ON USE OF AI

Ruinstars is still in beta and includes select concept art and visuals generated with the aid of AI image tools. While these assets support visual development and thematic exploration, they are not final and all images will be replaced with art created by actual artists by the time the game is released.

AT A GLANCE

- **Players:** 2 (PvP) • 1-2 (Solo/Co-op)
- **Session Length:** ~45-90 minutes depending on mission and squad size
- **Model Count:** 4-10 per side
- **Dice:** D6-based core resolution
- **Table Size:** Works on compact tables with dense terrain, typically 2' x 2'
- **Campaign:** Missions link into Operations: your Squad evolves, and each Mission has real consequences
- **Horde Mode:** A solo or co-op mode where your Squad faces increasingly tough waves of enemies

GETTING STARTED

1. Download the [Rules](#) (or [Printer-Friendly Version](#))
2. Play the introductory [first Mission](#)
3. Select your [Faction](#) and build your [Squad](#)
4. Gather some dice ([D6](#)), your miniatures, and [tokens](#)
5. Play your first [Core Mission](#) or start your [Campaign](#)!

For your first Mission, ignore Tactical Orders, Unit Skills, and Weapon Specials.

Instead, focus on the core concepts of actions, movement, and combat.

2. CORE MECHANICS

DICE ROLLS

Ruinstars uses 6-sided dice for all rolls. These will be indicated throughout the rules as **D6**.

Some rolls will require more than one die. For those, the number of dice to roll will be indicated before **D6**.

For example, to indicate a roll of 3 dice: **3D6**. To indicate a roll of 1 die: **1D6**.

SUCCESSSES AND FAILURES

When rolling against a character or weapon stat, a die roll is a success if its value is equal to or lower than that stat.

Irrespective of any modifiers or Stats, a die roll of **6** is always a failure.

Die rolls of **1** are always Critical successes and may have special effects depending on the roll in question (see Combat).

RE-ROLLS

Certain rules and events allow you to re-roll a die. In those cases, announce the die to be re-rolled, pick it up, and roll it again. Once a die is re-rolled, its result is final and it cannot be re-rolled again.

ALTERNATING ACTIVATIONS

During each Turn, Squads take turns Activating one Unit that has not yet been activated.

For example, during each Turn:

- Squad A activates its first Unit and performs Actions
- Squad B activates its first Unit and performs Actions
- Squad A activates its second Unit and performs Actions
- Squad B activates its second Unit and performs Actions
- etc.

In cases where one Squad has at least 2 more Standing Units than the other, the Squad with fewer Units may choose to delay one activation once per Turn. In that case, the Squad with more Units activates two of its Units in a row.

PACES

All movement and distance measurements are measured in **Paces**.

A Pace is typically 40mm or about 1.5". Use a ruler, or use our print-at-home Gauges for quick measurement. If you prefer, playing on a grid simplifies movement and measurement and avoids imprecision in moving miniatures and checking weapon ranges.

3. GAME CYCLE

MISSION START

SELECT MISSION

PREPARE BATTLEFIELD

DEPLOY UNITS

TURNS (1-4)

START OF TURN

ACTIVATE UNITS

END OF TURN

MISSION END

VICTORY

EARN XP

APPLY INJURIES

MISSION START

1. Select Mission

Select a Mission, scripted operation, or Horde mode

2. Prepare Battlefield

Prepare the battlefield as defined by the selected mission. Place terrain, markers, and items such as crates and barrels.

3. Deploy Units

Before deployment begins, both players roll off. The player who wins the roll-off then chooses which Squad gains the Initiative for Turn 1. Follow the Mission's briefing to deploy your Units. If both teams "deploy before Turn 1," players take turns placing one Unit at a time on the Battlefield, starting with the player who does not have the Turn 1 Initiative. The Squad with the Turn 1 Initiative will activate their Unit first in the Alternating Activations sequence.

TURNS

Missions typically have four Turns, but some Missions may have different conditions.

1. Start of Turn

1. Mark all Units as Ready (not Activated)
2. Resolve all "Start of Turn" skills or events
3. Roll-off for Initiative. Lowest roll wins Initiative and will Activate first.
4. Roll for Tactical Orders for the Turn
5. The Squad with the Initiative rolls for the Battlefield's Events (if any) for this Turn

2. Activate Units

The Squad with the Initiative activates their first Unit, then Squads alternate activating their Units until all Units have been activated.

See also Alternating Activations.

3. End of Turn

Resolve all "End of Turn" actions or events. Score Mission Points according to the selected Mission.

MISSION END

1. Victory

Determine the winner of the Mission according to the Mission briefing.

2. Earn XP

If playing a Campaign or Operation mission, apply XP and Medals to the Units. See also Campaigns.

3. Apply Injuries

If playing a Campaign or Operation mission, roll 1D6 for each Unit that was Taken Out at the end of the Mission, and apply the corresponding Injury. See also Campaigns.

ALTERNATING ACTIVATIONS

Ruinstars uses **Alternating Activations**:

During each Turn, Squads take turns Activating one Unit that has not yet been activated: Player 1 activates their first Unit, then player 2 activates their first Unit, followed by player 1 activating their second Unit etc. This ensures dynamic play and avoids having to wait long periods of time before you can actually *do* something with your Squad.

Each player takes alternating turns activating the Units in their Squad. For example, in order:

1. Player 1 activates their first Unit
2. Player 2 activates their first Unit
3. Player 1 activates their second Unit
4. Player 2 activates their second Unit
5. (etc)

At the start of each Turn, all Units are marked as "Ready". As each Unit completes their Activation, they are marked as "Activated".

If one Squad has at least 2 more Standing Units than the other, the Squad with fewer Standing Units may choose to delay one activation once per Turn. In that case, the Squad with more Units activates two of its Units in a row, then alternating Activations resume normally.

MISSION POINTS

Mission Points (MP) determine the winner of the battle. Each Mission will define conditions under which a Squad can score Mission Points. At the end of the Mission, the Squad with the most MP wins.

4. YOUR FIRST MISSION

This mission introduces the core flow of Ruinstars: actions, movement, combat, and objectives. These are the core concepts of the game. In your next missions, you can introduce more advanced topics like Tactical Orders, weapon specials, and Unit Skills.

WHAT YOU NEED

- 8 miniatures to represent 2 Squads of 4 Units each. Use the starting squad below.
- A 2'x2' battlefield.
- 4-6 pieces of terrain (ruins, barricades, whatever you have on hand)
- A handful of 6-sided dice
- This page and the first mission squad below

SETUP

1. Place terrain evenly across the battlefield
2. Place one objective marker in the center of the battlefield
3. Deploy both squads on opposite battlefield edges

THE MISSION

Secure The Ruin

- A Squad controls the Ruin if it has more Standing Units Adjacent to it than the opposing Squad
- If a Squad controls the Objective at the end of Turn 4, that Squad wins
- If neither Squad controls the Objective, the mission is a draw.

WHAT TO IGNORE FOR THIS MISSION

For your first game, do not use:

- Unit Skills
- Weapon Specials
- Tactical Orders
- Combat modifiers (cover, attacks of opportunity, etc.)
- Campaign effects (XP, medals, injuries, spoils of war)

WHEN YOU'RE READY

After this mission:

- Add Unit Skills and Weapon Specials
- Introduce Tactical Orders and Attacks of Opportunity
- Build your Squad for your preferred [Faction](#)
- Try one of the [Core Missions](#) or a [Scripted Operation](#), or start your own epic [Campaign](#)

Each layer adds depth, but the core concepts and mechanisms remain the same.

YOUR SQUAD

1. LEADER

ACT 3	ARM 3	HIT 4		
WEAPONS		ATT	SKL	
	Melee Weapon	3	4	
	Ranged Weapon	3	4	
Leader 20GP		FV: 2 XP: 0		

HOW TO PLAY

The only rules you need

Turn Sequence

1. Start the Turn
2. Players alternate activating one Unit at a time
3. During its activation, a Unit may spend its ACT (Actions) to:
 - Move up to 3 Paces
 - Dash up to 1 Pace
 - Shoot (see Combat below)
 - Fight (see Combat below)
4. End the Turn after all Units have been activated

These actions can occur in any order, but remember that repeating the same action during an activation costs one additional ACT. For example, if a Unit wants to Move twice, the first Move action will cost 1 ACT, and the second one will cost 2 ACT for a total of 3 ACT.

Combat (Simplified)

If a Unit is Adjacent to an enemy (less than 1 Pace apart), it must use its Melee weapon to attack that enemy.

1. Roll D6s equal to your weapon's ATT (Attacks) stat
2. Rolls equal to or lower than your weapon's SKL (Skill) stat are successful strikes
3. Target rolls 1D6 for each successful strike. For each roll equal to or lower than the target's ARM (Armor), the target's armor absorbs the strike.
4. For each remaining (unsaved) strike, the target loses 1 HIT. If the target reaches 0 HIT, it is Taken Out and removed from the battlefield.

WHY THIS MISSION EXISTS

This mission isn't about winning, it's about learning how Ruinstars feels and cementing the core concepts.

- Tight positioning
- Risk vs reward
- The cost of overextending
- The pressure of objectives

If this clicks, the rest of the rules will make sense.

2. TROOPER 1

ACT 2	ARM 3	HIT 3		
WEAPONS		ATT	SKL	
	Melee Weapon	3	3	
	Ranged Weapon	3	3	
Trooper 15GP		FV: 2 XP: 0		

3. TROOPER 2

ACT 2	ARM 3	HIT 3		
WEAPONS		ATT	SKL	
	Melee Weapon	3	3	
	Ranged Weapon	3	3	
Trooper 15GP		FV: 2 XP: 0		

4. TROOPER 3

ACT 2	ARM 3	HIT 3		
WEAPONS		ATT	SKL	
	Melee Weapon	3	3	
	Ranged Weapon	3	3	
Trooper 15GP		FV: 2 XP: 0		

5. STAT CARDS

StatCards describe your Units and their Weapons with numerical values, and any special Skills they may have. In general, the higher the stat number, the better the Unit or Weapon.

Note that in the app and on the website, you can click or tap Specials to view what they mean, and Skills or Equipment to get their full description.

For your first Mission, ignore weapon specials and Unit skills. Instead, focus on the core concepts of actions, movement, and combat.

1. TOLAND STRAK

ACT 3	ARM 4	HIT 5	
WEAPONS		ATT	SKL
 Combat Knife (2MC) ^{1GP}		2	4
 Reaper (2RC) ^{5GP}		4	5
SKILLS			
Leader 2*		Strategize* (1 ACT)	
SQUAD SPECIALTY			
Duty Before Death			
Duty Before Death: When this Unit reaches 0 HIT, it may perform one free basic or mission action before being removed from the battlefield. That action must be 1 ACT or less.			
Leader 2: This Unit gains +1 HIT, +1 RSK, +1 MSK, and Leader 2: While this Unit is Standing, you may roll an additional 2 dice to determine Tactical Orders every turn.			
Strategize (1ACT): This Unit's Squad gains +1 TO.			
Strike Trooper 13+6GP			FV: 2 XP: 0

UNIT STATS

- **ACT** - Action Points
The maximum number of Action Points this Unit can spend on Actions during its activation.
- **ARM** - Armor
Indicates how well this Unit resists damage during combat.
When rolling Armor Saves, results of this stat or lower are successful.
- **HIT** - Hit Points
The Unit's number of Hit Points. When a Unit reaches zero **HIT**, it is **Taken Out** and removed from the battlefield (see Combat).
If a Unit has at least 1 **HIT** remaining, it is considered to be **Standing**.
- **GP** - Gear Points
The total cost in Gear Points (GP) for this Unit.
- **FV** - Force Value
The Force Value of this Unit. **FV** is used in some missions to determine a Unit's contribution to Mission Points. For example, in the Attrition Mission, Squads gain MPs equal to Taken Out Units' Force Value.
- **XP** - Experience Points
The Experience this unit has gained in battle. XP can be used to add certain special gear (skills or weapons) to a Unit.

Note that in the app and on the website, each special (e.g. **2RC**) and skill (e.g. "Duty Before Death") can be clicked or tapped to view their detailed description.

For example:

- Toland Strak is a Strike Trooper
- He can perform 3 Actions (**ACT**) during each of his activations.
- Each time he is the target of Combat and rolls Armor Saves, each result of 4 or less (**ARM**) is a successful Save.
- He starts each Mission with 5 Hit Points (**HIT**).

WEAPON STATS

-   - Weapon Type
 indicates a Melee weapon,  indicates a Ranged weapon.
- **ATT** - Attacks
How many Dice are rolled each time this Weapon is used.
- **SKL** - Skill
Indicates the skill of this Unit when using this Weapon. Rolls that are equal to or less than this value are successful strikes.
- **(SPECIAL)** - Weapon Specials
Specials for this weapon are listed next to its name. In the app and on the website, click or tap on them to read their full description. Don't worry about remembering the codes; they will quickly become second nature to you.

For example:

- Toland Strak's **Reaper** is a Ranged weapon ().
- Each time it is used, Toland Strak rolls 4 dice (**ATT**).
- Each result of 5 or less (**SKL**) is a success.

SKILLS

Some Units will have Skills listed on their StatCard. These are unique properties of that Unit that may allow them to perform a specific unique Action, or gain a bonus (or debuff) for certain game mechanics.

- Skills that have an **ACT** cost can be performed using the Unit's **ACT** Stat or a Tactical Order, or a combination of both.
- Skills that have a **TO** cost cannot be performed using the Unit's **ACT** Stat; they must be performed by spending Tactical Orders.
- Skills and Equipment that do not have an **ACT** or **TO** cost are passive skills that do not require spending an Action Point or Tactical Order.

For example, Toland Strak has 3 skills: Duty Before Death, Leader 2*, Strategize*.

6. ACTIONS

During its activation, a Unit can perform a number of Actions up to its **ACT** stat (see StatCards).

Each Action costs a number of Action Points or **ACT**.

Actions with an **ACT** cost can be performed by spending the Unit's **ACT** Action Points or the Squad's Tactical Orders, or any combination of the two (for example, if a Unit's skill costs 2 **ACT**, you can spend 1 **ACT** + 1 **TO** to perform that action).

Actions with a **TO** cost can only be performed by spending the Squad's Tactical Orders.

Each action costs its listed number of **ACT** the first time it is performed in a Unit's Activation. Each time that same action is repeated in the same Activation, it costs one additional **ACT**.

For example, a Unit with 3 **ACT** may perform 2 Moves in its Activation. The first Move costs 1 **ACT**, and the second one costs 2 **ACT**.

BASIC ACTIONS

All Units can perform the following Actions during their Activation:

Action	ACT	Description
Move	1	The Unit moves up to 3 Paces.
Dash	1	The Unit moves up to 1 Pace. This movement follows the same rules as a <u>normal Move</u> .
Ranged Combat	1	The Unit makes a Ranged attack against a valid target. See <u>Ranged Combat</u> .
Melee Combat	1	The Unit makes a Melee attack against an Adjacent target. See <u>Melee Combat</u> .
Pick Up	1	The Unit picks up an Adjacent marker or token.
Drop	1	The Unit drops a marker or token it is carrying in a position Adjacent to the Unit.
Give	1	The Unit passes a marker or token to an Adjacent Squadmate. The Unit cannot perform this Action if either Unit is <u>Adjacent</u> to any enemy Units.
Open/Close Door	1	The Unit opens or closes an Adjacent door.
Mission Action	-	Mission Actions are special mission-specific Actions that can be performed according to the Mission Briefing.

Unfamiliar terms and weapon specials are defined in the Glossary.

MISSION ACTIONS

Certain Missions will define special Actions that can be performed by Units. Read the Mission Briefing to determine if the Mission defines any such Actions.

TACTICAL ORDERS

For your first Mission, ignore Tactical Orders. Instead, focus on the core concepts of actions, movement, and combat.

At the start of each Turn, players roll for **Tactical Orders** (**TO**). Each roll of 1-3 is a success and give that Squad 1 **TO**. The number of dice to roll is:

- **Base:** 3D6. All Squads roll at least 3 dice for Tactical Orders.
- **Leader:** If the Squad's Leader is still Standing, add dice for its Leader skill (e.g. "Leader 2" means roll an additional 2 dice for Tactical Orders, for a total of 5).
- **Taken Out:** For each Unit that was Taken Out during the Mission, the Squad gains 1 additional Tactical Order die (e.g. if 2 Units were Taken Out, the Squad gains 2 Tactical Orders on top of the results of the roll).

At the end of each Turn, any unused Tactical Orders are lost; they do not carry over to the following Turn.

Note that rolling for Tactical Orders cannot be modified by using Tactical Orders.

USING TACTICAL ORDERS

Tactical Orders may be spent to:

- Perform a Unit's **TO** Skill. Unless otherwise indicated, **TO** skills cannot be performed more than once per Turn
- Perform an Additional Basic or Mission Action during a Unit's Activation.
- Re-roll any one die for any of your rolls (including during one of your opponent's Units' Activations, for example during Melee combat).
- Change the result of one of your rolled dice by +/- 1. Note that this is stackable; you can spend 2 **TO** to reduce the result of a die by 2, or spend multiple **TO** on multiple dice in a given roll. Modifying a die roll in this way does not trigger roll-specific effects (e.g. reducing an Attack die roll of 2 to 1 does not mean it is a Critical success).

7. MOVEMENT

BATTLEFIELD

The Battlefield is typically 2' by 2', or 60cm x 60cm. All movement and distance/range measurements are done by counting **Paces**.

You can bring your own battlefield, or use our print-at-home [Battlefields](#) with the tiles and Paces pre-marked.

If you prefer to play with a grid, see [Playing on a Grid](#) for details.

TILES

The Battlefield is divided into 9 equal Tiles, each being 5x5 Paces (8" or 20cm to a side). Some missions may describe their setup in terms of a Tile's position (e.g. "Western Tile", "Center Tile", "SouthEast Tile"). Before the mission, both players should agree which way is North on the Battlefield, then refer to this diagram to find the right Tile.



PACES

All movement and distance measurements are measured in **Paces**.

A Pace is typically 40mm or about 1.5". Use a ruler, or use our print-at-home [Gauges](#) for quick measurement. If you prefer, playing on a [grid](#) provides simplicity of movement and measurement and avoids imprecision in moving miniatures and checking weapon ranges.

MOVEMENT

When a Unit performs a Move Action, the maximum distance it can travel is **3** Paces. Movement should be made in increments of 1 Pace. If a Unit wants to move in one direction for less than 1 Pace, it still counts as 1 Pace.

A Unit may not move in a way that would require its base to cover an enemy Unit's base at any point in the movement.

ADJACENT

Two Units or Items are considered to be **Adjacent** if:

- The closest edges of their bases are within 1 Pace of each other,
- They are on the same elevation, and
- There is no wall between them.

CONTROL

A Unit **Controls** a marker or objective if all the following conditions are met:

- The Unit is Adjacent to that marker,
- The Unit is not Adjacent to any enemy Units, and
- The marker is not Adjacent to any enemy Units

ATTACK OF OPPORTUNITY

When a Unit Moves or Dashes out of Adjacency to an enemy Unit, that enemy may immediately perform a free Melee attack against the moving Unit. This is called an **Attack of Opportunity**.

If the moving Unit is Adjacent to multiple enemies, only one of those enemies may perform an Attack of Opportunity, though they still get support in the Melee Combat Action.

The moving Unit may choose to spend some or all of its remaining movement Paces to blunt the attack. For each Pace of movement it spends in this way, reduce the number of attack dice the enemy rolls (the weapon's **ATT** stat) by **1**.

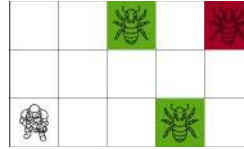
Each Unit can perform only one Attack of Opportunity per Turn.

DISTANCES AND RANGE

To measure the distance between two Units or Items (for example, to check if a target is within the Range of a given Ranged Weapon), only measure on the Horizontal plane; ignore vertical distance.

The target is considered to be in range of that weapon if the distance in Paces is equal to or lower than the weapon's range.

If a Ranged weapon does not have a specified Range (**RNGx**), its range is infinite.



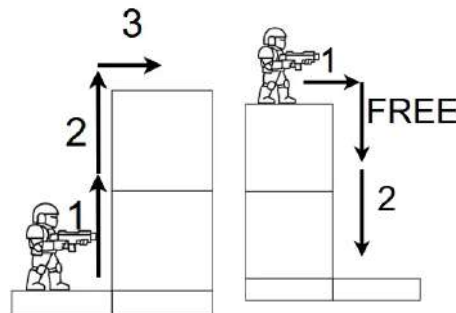
*The soldier has a Ranged weapon with a range of **3** Paces (**RNG3**). The bugs marked in **green** are within range, while the bugs marked in **red** are out of range.*

VERTICAL MOVEMENT

Climbing up vertical terrain costs 1 Pace per vertical Pace, plus 1 Pace for the horizontal direction desired.

Note that for a Unit to climb a wall, that wall must be mutually agreed by all players to be Climbable at the start of the battle. Generally these walls will be easily identifiable with a ladder or other visual marker indicating it is climbable.

Climbing down a wall follows the same rules as climbing up, but vertical movement costs 1 less Pace.



8. COMBAT

*For your first Mission, ignore combat modifiers, weapon specials, and attacks of opportunity.
Instead, focus on the core concepts of actions, movement, and combat.*

RANGED COMBAT

SEQUENCE

1. Select Target

- The Attacker selects one of their Ranged weapons to use
- The Attacker selects a valid Target. The Target must:
 - Not be Adjacent to the Attacker or the Attacker's Squadmates
 - Be within the Weapon's range (**RNGx**)
 - Be in the Attacker's Line of Sight

A Unit may not perform this action if it is Adjacent to any enemy Units.

2. Roll Attacks

- Roll a number of dice equal to the weapon's **ATT** (Attacks).
- Each die result equal to or less than the weapon's **SKL** (Skill) is a successful strike and inflicts 1 point of Damage on the Target.
 - A roll of **1** is a **Critical Strike** and inflicts 2 points of Damage
 - A roll of **6** is always a failure

3. Roll Armor Saves

- The Target rolls one die per point of Damage inflicted.
- Each result equal to or less than the Target's **ARM** (Armor) is a successful Save.
 - A roll of **1** is a **Critical Save** and counts as 2 Saves
 - A roll of **6** is always a failure
- Each unsaved point of Damage causes the Target to lose 1 **HIT**
- If a Unit reaches zero **HIT**, it is Taken Out and removed from the battlefield.

MODIFIERS

Condition	Description
Cover	If the Target is in <u>cover</u> , the Target gets one automatic Armor Save (without having to roll it)
High Ground	If the Attacker is at least 2 Paces higher than its Target, the Target does not benefit from Cover

LINE OF SIGHT

A Target is said to be in an Attacker's **Line of Sight** if two uninterrupted lines can be drawn from one of the point of the Attacker's base to two opposite edges of the Target's base.

A Unit cannot target an enemy Unit for Ranged Combat if there are other Units on that Line of Sight (i.e. a Unit cannot shoot "through" other Units).



SPECIAL CASES

These rules mean that in some cases, a Unit may be able to target an enemy Unit even if that Unit cannot target them in return.

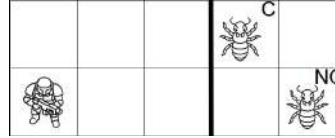


The soldier may target the Bug in Ranged Combat, but the Bug may not target the soldier because the two lines to the Soldier's base are blocked by a wall.

COVER

If a Target is only partially visible to the Attacker (for example, there is a short wall between the two Units), that Target is said to be in cover. Cover only applies to Ranged attacks; there is no Cover benefit for Melee attacks.

A Target is in Cover if a piece of terrain blocks the Attacker's full view of the Target and that terrain is within 1 Pace of the Target.



*The bug marked **C** is in Cover. The bug marked **NC** is not in Cover because the wall is not within 1 Pace of the Target.*

MELEE COMBAT

SEQUENCE

1. Select Target

- The Attacker selects one of their Melee weapons to use
- The Target must be Adjacent to the Attacker

2. Roll Attacks

- Roll a number of dice equal to the weapon's **ATT** (Attacks).
- Each die result equal to or less than the weapon's **SKL** (Skill) is a successful strike and inflicts 1 point of Damage on the Target.
 - A roll of **1** is a **Critical Strike** and inflicts 2 points of Damage
 - A roll of **6** is always a failure

3. Roll Armor Saves

- The Target rolls one die per point of Damage inflicted.
- Each result equal to or less than the Target's **ARM** (Armor) is a successful Save.
 - A roll of **1** is a **Critical Save**:
 - It blocks 1 point of Damage, and
 - Inflicts 1 point of Melee Damage on the Attacker. The Attacker then rolls their own Armor Saves for that returned Damage.
 - This effect can chain: if the Attacker then rolls a Critical Save, they return damage to the Target, and so on.
 - A roll of **6** is always a failure
- Each unsaved point of Damage causes the Target to lose 1 **HIT**
- If a Unit reaches zero **HIT**, it is Taken Out and removed from the battlefield.

Unfamiliar terms and weapon specials are defined in the Glossary.

MODIFIERS

Condition	Description
Support - Attacker	For each of the Attacker's Squadmates Adjacent to the Target, the Attacker may re-roll one Attack die.
Support - Target	For each of the Target's Squadmates Adjacent to the Target, the Target may re-roll one Save die.

ATTACK OF OPPORTUNITY

When a Unit Moves or Dashes out of Adjacency to an enemy Unit, that enemy may immediately perform a free Melee attack against the moving Unit. This is called an **Attack of Opportunity**.

If the moving Unit is Adjacent to multiple enemies, only one of those enemies may perform an Attack of Opportunity, though they still get support in the Melee Combat Action.

The moving Unit may choose to spend some or all of its remaining movement Paces to blunt the attack. For each Pace of movement it spends in this way, reduce the number of attack dice the enemy rolls (the weapon's **ATT** stat) by **1**.

Each Unit can perform only one Attack of Opportunity per Turn.

9. ITEMS

You may choose to add items to the battlefield that have special purposes and behaviors, and some missions may require the placement of items.

PLACEMENT

To place items randomly on the battlefield, players take turns rolling for random placement.

For each item to be placed:

- Roll **1D10** to determine which Tile to place the item on. On a roll of **10**, the player chooses which Tile to place the item on.
- Roll **1D6** to determine the X coordinate (in Paces) within that Tile to place the item on. On a roll of **6**, the player chooses which coordinate to place the item on.
- Roll **1D6** to determine the Y coordinate (in Paces) within that Tile to place the item on. On a roll of **6**, the player chooses which coordinate to place the item on.

BARRELS

Barrels are explosive containers that can be attacked, causing an explosion.

If you choose to play with Barrels, randomly place 5 Barrels on the battlefield.

Barrels may be attacked in Ranged or Melee combat. The Barrel is a Unit that cannot roll Armor Saves; if it is attacked in combat and at least one strike is successful, it explodes. When a Barrel explodes, it causes an explosion dealing 2 Ranged Damage to all Adjacent Units and Items, then it is removed from the Battlefield.

CRATES

If you choose to play with Crates, randomly place 4 Crates on the battlefield. To open a crate, a Unit must be Adjacent to the crate and spend 1 **ACT** to open it. This counts as a Mission Action. When opened, roll **1D6** to determine the contents of that Crate, then remove it from the Battlefield:

1. **TO**

The Unit's Squad immediately gains 1 Tactical Order.

2. **Relay Order**

The Unit may immediately perform a free Basic or Mission Action.

3. **Map**

The Unit or one of its Squadmates may immediately perform a free Move Action.

4. **MedPack**

The Unit gains a MedPack. This MedPack can be used for 1 **ACT** during any of this Unit's activations. When used, the Unit or an Adjacent Squadmate regains **1D3** lost **HIT**. The MedPack may not be used if this Unit or the selected Squadmate are Adjacent to any Enemy Units. Once used, remove the MedPack from the Unit.

5. **Nothing**

The Crate is empty, nothing happens.

6. **Booby Trap**

The crate explodes, dealing 2 Ranged Damage to all Adjacent Units and Items.

10. CAMPAIGNS

CAMPAIGN STRUCTURE

A Campaign is composed of three Operations, and each Operation is composed of three Missions.

At the end of each Operation, your Squad returns to Homebase to heal injuries, resupply, and recruit new Units into the Squad.

To build a Campaign, randomly select the nine missions from the list of Missions, or string together three Scripted Operations.

OPERATIONS

An Operation represents a critical deployment arc within the larger Campaign structure, which is generally composed of three sequential Missions. When the Operation begins, your Squad is considered in the field. While deployed in the field, the Squad cannot change its Units or Gear selections, and any Gear Points (GP) or Experience Points (XP) earned during these missions cannot be spent on new Units or Gear.

Once the third Mission of an Operation is complete, your Squad returns to Homebase to heal injuries, make new Gear selections, and recruit new Units by spending GP and XP.

HOMEBASE

At the end of each Operation (after the third Mission), your Squad returns to Homebase to heal injuries, resupply, and utilize accrued resources.

1. Remove all Deceased Units from your Squad.
2. Remove all Injuries from remaining Units.
3. Recruit new Units into the Squad. Deceased Units can only be replaced during this Homebase phase.
4. Make changes to your Squad's selected Gear and Spoils Of War.

SAMPLE CAMPAIGN

- Operation 1 - The Facility
 - Mission 1.1 - Retrieve Intel
 - Mission 1.2 - Intercept
 - Mission 1.3 - Sabotage
- Homebase
- Operation 2 - The Ruined City
 - Mission 2.1 - Rivals
 - Mission 2.2 - Scavenge
 - Mission 2.3 - Control
- Homebase
- Operation 3 - No Man's Land
 - Mission 3.1 - Defend
 - Mission 3.2 - Infiltrate
 - Mission 3.3 - Eradicate

INJURIES

At the end of each Mission, each of your Units that were Taken Out during the mission may have a persistent injury. Note that when playing a campaign, all Injuries (except Deceased) are removed from your Units when they return to Homebase at the end of each Operation.

At the end of each Mission, for each Unit that was Taken Out, roll 1D6 to determine the Injury this Unit received.

If the Injury is one that the Unit already had, that Unit is Deceased. Remove the Unit from the Squad. That Unit cannot be replaced until the Squad returns to Homebase at the end of the Operation.

If the Injury is Healed, remove one other Injury from that Unit. If it has no other Injuries, Healed has no effect.

- 1-2 - HEALED
 - Remove one Injury from this Unit.
- 3 - BODILY INJURY
 - The Unit gets -1 MSK (minimum 1).
- 4 - HEAD INJURY
 - The Unit gets -1 RSK (minimum 1).
- 5 - IMPAIRED MOVEMENT
 - Each time the Unit performs the Move action, it moves 1 less Pace.
- 6 - DAMAGED ARMOR
 - The Unit gets -1 ARM (minimum 1).
- DECEASED

If the Unit receives an Injury that it already possesses (e.g. rolling a 6/Damaged Armor when it already has Damaged Armor), that Unit is instead Deceased. A Deceased Unit is permanently removed from the Squad and cannot be used in future Missions. It may be replaced when the Squad returns to Homebase.

MEDALS

As your Squad completes Missions and achieves objectives, it grows in skill and available resources.

During each Mission, your Squad's Units gain XP from medals as described below. Each Medal can only be claimed once per Unit.

- **ASSASSIN - 2 XP**
This Unit took out an enemy Leader in a Mission.
- **AVENGER - 2 XP**
This Unit took out an enemy Unit after that enemy Unit took their Leader out.
- **BLOODTHIRSTY 1 - 2 XP**
This Unit took out two enemy Units in the same Turn.
- **DEADLY FIGHTER - 2 XP**
This Unit Took Out an enemy Unit as a result of a Critical Save in Melee combat.
- **FIRST BLOOD 1 - 1 XP**
This Unit was the first one to take an enemy out in a Mission in Operation 1.
- **FIRST BLOOD 2 - 1 XP**
This Unit was the first one to take an enemy out in a Mission in Operation 2.
- **LAST STANDING - 2 XP**
This Unit was the last Standing Unit in its Squad at the end of a Mission.
- **OPERATION CLEAR - 1 XP**
This Unit's Squad scored at least 2 victories in a single Operation.
- **OVERKILL - 1 XP**
This Unit Took Out an enemy Unit in Combat by inflicting 3 more unsaved successful strikes than that Unit's remaining HIT.
- **OVERWHELMING FORCE - 2 XP**
This Unit's Squad Took Out all enemy Units in a Mission without any of this Squad's Units being taken out.
- **RESOURCEFUL - 1 XP**
This Unit took out an enemy Unit using an Item (e.g. Barrel, Turret).
- **SCAVENGER - 1 XP**
This Unit opened a Crate in a Mission.
- **UNDERDOG - 1 XP**
This Unit Took Out an enemy Unit with with a higher FV.
- **UNTOUCHABLE - 2 XP**
This Unit was still Standing at the end of a Mission and had all its HIT remaining.
- **VETERAN 1 - 1 XP**
This Unit was still Standing at the end of a Mission in Operation 1.
- **VETERAN 2 - 1 XP**
This Unit was still Standing at the end of a Mission in Operation 2.
- **VICTOR 1 - 1 XP**
This Unit's Squad won one Mission in Operation 1.
- **VICTOR 2 - 1 XP**
This Unit's Squad won one Mission in Operation 2.

SPOILS OF WAR

For each increment of 5 XP earned, a Unit may take one Spoil Of War when it returns to Homebase at the end of an Operation (unless it is Deceased).

For example, a Unit with 13 XP can take 2 Spoils Of War.

- **ACCURATE 1**
This Unit may re-roll up to 1 of its Ranged Combat attack dice. This is cumulative with other Accurate specials (e.g. on this Unit's weapons).
- **BRUTAL 1**
This Unit may re-roll up to 1 of its Melee Combat attack dice. This is cumulative with other Brutal specials (e.g. on this Unit's weapons).
- **COUNTER**
Each time this Unit is the primary target of a Melee Attack, if this Unit did not lose any HIT by the end of that Combat, it may immediately perform a Melee Attack against the original Attacker.
- **DODGE 1**
Each time this Unit is the target of a Ranged Combat attack, it may re-roll up to 1 of its Armor Saves. This is cumulative with other Dodge specials.
- **MELEE ATT +1**
This Unit's Melee weapons gain + 1 ATT.
- **MELEE CHAIN REACTION 1**
This Unit's Melee Weapons gain CHR1 (Chain Reaction 1).
- **MELEE RELENTLESS**
This Unit's Melee weapons gain RLT (Relentless).
- **MELEE RENDING 1**
This Unit's Melee weapons gain RND1 (Rending 1).
- **RANGED ATT +1**
This Unit's Ranged weapons gain + 1 ATT.
- **RANGED BLAST**
This Unit's Ranged Weapons gain BLS (Blast).
- **RANGED RELENTLESS**
This Unit's Ranged weapons gain RLT (Relentless).
- **RANGED RENDING 1**
This Unit's Ranged weapons gain RND1 (Rending 1).
- **SWIFT**
Each time this Unit performs the Dash action, it costs one less ACT. This means that the first time this Unit performs a Dash in each of its Activations, it costs zero ACT.
- **TECHNICIAN**
During each of its Activations, this Unit may perform one Mission action for 1 less ACT.
- **TOUGH 1**
Each time this Unit is the target of a Melee Combat attack, it may re-roll up to 1 of its Armor Saves. This is cumulative with other Tough specials.
- **TREASURE TROVE**
The Squad can spend an additional 5GP on Units and Gear. Increase the Squad's MaxGP by 5.

11. GLOSSARY

Activation

The process during a Turn where a Unit performs Actions. A Unit is "Activated" once it has taken its turn and cannot be Activated again that Turn.

Action Point (ACT)

Points a Unit spends to perform Actions during its Activation. Each Unit has a maximum ACT value listed on its StatCard.

Adjacent

Two Units or Items are considered to be Adjacent if: The closest edges of their bases are within 1 Pace of each other, They are on the same elevation, and There is no wall between them.

Armor Save

A die roll made when a Unit is hit in Combat to prevent Damage. A result equal to or less than the Unit's ARM stat is a success.

Battlefield

The game board on which the Mission is played.

Campaign

A series of Missions grouped into Operations. Units gain Medals, XP, GP, Injuries, and Spoils Of War during Campaign play.

Control

A Unit Controls an objective marker if it is Adjacent to that marker, it is not Adjacent to any enemy Units, and that marker is not Adjacent to any enemy Units.

Critical Strike

A Combat die roll of 1. Automatically inflicts double Damage (2 points) instead of 1. May have special effects.

Critical Save

A Save die roll of 1. Counts as 2 Saves in Ranged Combat, and causes returned Damage in Melee Combat.

Damage

Damage inflicted during Combat. Resolved by rolling Armor Saves.

Deceased

A Unit is Deceased if it has been permanently removed from the Squad due to being Taken Out in a Mission and failing its Injury roll.

Effect

A special battlefield rule or ongoing condition applied by the selected Battlefield or Mission.

Elevation

The vertical distance of a terrain feature. Relevant for determining high ground, climbing, adjacency, and line of sight.

Gear

The various Weapons, Skills, and Abilities available to a Unit.

Gear Points (GP)

The point value used to build Squads. Each Unit and item of Gear costs a certain amount of GP. The standard limit is 100 GP per Squad.

Initiative

Determines which Squad activates a Unit first in each Turn. Decided by a roll-off at the start of the Turn.

Item

A game element placed on the Battlefield that can be interacted with (e.g. Crates, Spawn Points, Barrels).

Leader

A single Unit in a given Squad that is the Squad's Leader. Leaders contribute extra dice to Tactical Orders each Turn and are often high-value targets.

Line of Sight (LoS)

A Unit has Line of Sight to a Target if two unobstructed lines can be drawn from its base to two opposite edges of the Target's base.

Mission Point (MP)

Points awarded for completing objectives. The Squad with the most MP at the end of a Mission wins.

Narrative Gear

Special campaign-only gear, effects, or injuries enabled in Campaign mode. Includes Spoils Of War and persistent Injuries.

Special (Weapon Special)

An abbreviation or keyword attached to a weapon that indicates a rule or effect beyond base stats (e.g. 2RC, HVY, RNG3).

Spoils Of War

Permanent bonuses earned by Units through campaign XP. Examples include Accurate, Brutal, or Technician.

Standing

Opposite of "Taken Out". A Unit is considered Standing if it has 1 or more HIT remaining and has not been Taken Out.

StatCard

A Unit's profile listing all of its combat stats, weapons, skills, and cost.

Tactical Orders (TO)

Extra resources rolled at the start of each Turn. Used to perform bonus actions, re-rolls, or TO-only skills.

Taken Out

Opposite of "Standing". A Unit is Taken Out when its HIT is reduced to 0. It is removed from the battlefield and may receive an Injury during campaign play.

Tile

See Battlefield Tile. Each battlefield is divided into 9 tiles that may affect setup and effects.

Turn

A phase of the game during which both Squads alternate activating Units. Each game typically consists of four Turns.

Unit

An individual model in a Squad. Each Unit has its own StatCard, can perform Actions, and can be affected by Skills, Gear, or Effects.

SPECIALS

* - Unique

A Squad cannot include this Gear more than once.

+SKL - Improve Skill

Improves this Weapon's MSK/RSK by 1.

2MC - Double Melee

During each of its Activations, the second time this Unit performs the Melee Combat action with this weapon costs 1 less ACT.

2RC - Double Ranged

During each of its Activations, the second time this Unit performs the Ranged Combat action with this weapon costs 1 less ACT.

ACCx - Accurate x

Each time this Weapon is used in Ranged Combat, the Attacker may re-roll up to x of its Attack dice.

AUTx - Autohit x

Each time this weapon is used in Combat, x of this Weapon's Attack dice is an automatic Strike without rolling it. You may still choose to roll that die.

BLDX - Blindside x

Each time this Unit uses this weapon, if the target has already been activated during this Turn, this Weapon gains +x ATT.

BLS - Blast

Each time the Unit uses this weapon, it fires against the target and any other Adjacent Units (including Squadmates) visible to the original target. Roll Attack dice once and apply the resulting strikes to each affected Unit.

BRUX - Brutal x

Each time this weapon is used in Melee Combat, the Attacker may re-roll up to x of its Melee Combat attack dice.

CHRx - Chain Reaction x

Each time this weapon is used in Combat, after resolving the Attack on the primary target, you may apply the same Attack roll's strikes on up to x other secondary targets Adjacent to the original target.

DDL - Deadly

Attack rolls of 1 and 2 are Critical Strikes.

HIT - Hit Strikes

This Weapon's ATT is equal to this Unit's remaining HIT.

HVY - Heavy

This weapon penalizes the Unit's movement and firing actions: - If the Unit performs a Move Action, its next combat action performed with this weapon costs 1 additional ACT. - If the Unit uses this weapon in combat, its next Move Action costs 1 additional ACT. Units can perform a Dash Action with this weapon equipped without any penalties.

LIM - Limited Ammo

This weapon can only be used once during each Mission.

NCV - No Cover

Each time this Weapon is used in combat, targets do not benefit from Cover.

PBK - Point Blank

This Ranged weapon can target an adjacent Enemy. Note using this weapon in this way is still a Ranged attack.

PRCx - Piercing x

Each time this weapon is used in combat, the target gets -x ARM.

RLT - Relentless

Each time this Weapon is used in combat, you may re-roll all die results of 6.

RNDx - Rendering x

Each time this weapon is used in combat, up to x Critical Strikes cause 3 Damage (instead of 2).

RNGx - Range x

The weapon's maximum range for target selection is x Paces.

SKLx - Skill x

Instead of using the Unit's Ranged or Melee Skill, use x as the Skill when using this weapon in combat.

SPR - Spread

Each time this Weapon is used, the Unit may select multiple targets as long as each selected target is a valid target and is Adjacent to another selected target. If multiple targets are selected, distribute this weapon's Attack Dice between these selected targets and perform attacks accordingly. Allocate at least one Attack die to each selected Target.

STN - Stun

Each time this Unit uses this weapon, if it rolls at least one Critical Strike, the target gets -1 ACT in its next Activation (minimum 1).

12. PLAYING ON A GRID

While Ruinstars is designed for freeform placement and movement on the battlefield, you can also play on a grid to simplify movement and measurements.

BATTLEFIELD

The Battlefield is a 15x15 grid of Squares, each one exactly 1 Pace (40mm or 1.5in) to a side. All movement and distance/range measurements are done by counting Squares.

You can bring your own battlefield, or use our print-at-home [Battlefields](#) with the Tiles and Squares ready to go.

TILES

The Battlefield is divided into 9 equal Tiles, each composed of 5x5 Squares/Paces.

Some missions may describe their setup in terms of a Tile's position (e.g. "Western Tile", "Center Tile", "SouthEast Tile"). Before the mission, both players should agree which way is North on the Battlefield, then refer to this diagram to find the right Tile.



MOVEMENT

When a Unit moves on the Battlefield, the maximum distance it can travel is 3 Squares. Movement can be done along any cardinal direction (North, South, East, West) or in diagonal (North-East, North-West, South-East, South-West).

SQUARES

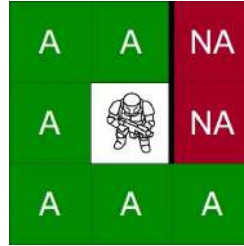
All movement and distance measurements are measured in Squares. No need for tape measures, gauges, or rulers!

Using a grid provides simplicity of movement and measurement and avoids imprecision in moving miniatures and checking weapon ranges.

ADJACENT SQUARES

All 8 Squares surrounding a given Square are considered to be **Adjacent** to that Square. When selecting a valid target for Melee combat, the attacker and its target must be in Adjacent Squares. Two Squares that are on different elevations are not considered to be Adjacent.

If a wall that is 1 Square or taller is between two Squares, those two Squares are not considered to be Adjacent.



The Squares marked A are Adjacent to the Unit. The Squares marked NA are blocked by a wall and are not Adjacent to the Unit.

13. QUICK REFERENCE

TURN SEQUENCE

1. **Start of Turn:** Each Squad performs its "Start of Turn" abilities (if any)
2. **Tactical Orders:** Each player rolls for Tactical Orders. Results of 1-3 are successes (+1 TO)
3. **Initiative:** Each player rolls-off for Initiative. Lowest result has the initiative
4. **Battlefield Events:** The player with the initiative resolves battlefield events
5. **Alternating Activations:** Starting with the player with the initiative, players take turns activating one unit at a time until all units have activated. Once per Turn, the Squad with the fewest Standing Units may delay one of its activations.
6. **End of Turn:** Each Squad performs its "End of Turn" abilities (if any)
7. **Reset:** Reset Tactical Orders (TOs) to zero

BASIC ACTIONS

- **Move (1ACT):** The Unit moves up to 3 Paces
- **Dash (1ACT):** The Unit moves up to 1 Pace
- **Ranged Combat (1ACT):** The Unit performs a Ranged Combat attack against a valid target
- **Melee Combat (1ACT):** The Unit performs a Melee Combat attack against a valid target

A Unit may perform the same Action multiple times during its activation, but it costs 1 additional ACT each time it is repeated.

RANGED COMBAT

1. Select Target: Must be in range, in LoS, not Adjacent to attacker.
2. Roll **ATT** dice: Dice at or below **SKL** deal 1 damage (1 = Crit: 2 damage).
3. Target Rolls **ARM** saves per damage: Dice at or below **ARM** save 1 damage.
4. Critical Save: Blocks 2 damage.
5. Cover: Target gains 1 auto-save if partially obscured.
6. High Ground: Attacker 2+ levels higher than Target negates cover.

MELEE COMBAT

1. Select Target: Must be adjacent.
2. Roll **ATT** dice: Dice at or below **SKL** deal 1 damage (1 = Crit: 2 damage).
3. Target Rolls **ARM** saves per damage: Dice at or below **ARM** save 1 damage.
4. Critical Save: Blocks 1 damage *and* inflicts 1 Melee damage back (can chain).
5. Support - Attacker: +1 attack re-roll per adjacent squadmate vs target.
6. Support - Target: +1 save re-roll per adjacent squadmate.

CRATES

Roll 1D6, then remove the Crate from the Battlefield:

1. **TO**
The Unit's Squad immediately gains 1 Tactical Order.
2. **Relay Order**
The Unit may immediately perform a free Basic or Mission Action.
3. **Map**
The Unit or one of its Squadmates may immediately perform a Move Action.
4. **MedPack**
The Unit gains a MedPack. This MedPack can be used for 1 ACT during any of this Unit's activations. When used, the Unit or an Adjacent Squadmate regain 1D3 lost **HIT**. The MedPack may not be used if this Unit or the selected Squadmate are Adjacent to any Enemy Units. Once used, remove the MedPack from the Unit.
5. **Nothing**
The Crate is empty, nothing happens.
6. **Booby Trap**
The crate explodes, dealing 2 Ranged Damage to all Adjacent Units and Items.

AFTERWORD

COMMUNITY

This is a community-driven project, and we welcome contributions, feedback, and suggestions. If you have ideas for new features, improvements, or just want to chat about the game, please join our community channels.

- Ruinstars.com - Main website and app
- [Discord](#) - Come say hello!
- itch.io - Includes devlogs for the game
- [GitHub](#) - Full source code
- [WargameVault](#)
- [BoardGameGeek](#)

NEWS AND CHANGES

HORDE MODE

Dec 13, 2025

Horde Mode rules are live!

DEVLOG: PREVIEWING HORDE MODE

Dec 11, 2025

New DevLog! We've been working on **Horde Mode**, a solo/coop mode of endless waves of enemies where no two runs are the same. Check it out!

BATTLEFIELD DIAGRAMS

Dec 7, 2025

All primary missions now include a diagram of the battlefield, including deployment zones, markers, etc. Check it out!

MISSION TYPES AND REWARDS + SPOILS OF WAR

Nov 26, 2025

Primary missions now include two rewards, with the winning Squad selecting their reward first, and the losing Squad selecting the other. Plus new Spoils Of War! See the devlog here for more info!

SQUAD ADJUSTMENTS - HUNTER KILLERS AND DESPOILERS

Nov 5, 2025

The Hunter Killers and Despoilers have been updated with more options, tweaks to their skills, and general balance updates.

NEW SQUAD TYPE - HUNTER KILLERS

Oct 31, 2025

The Hunter Killers of the Swarm strike with purpose: flanking prey, dismantling defenses, and leaving nothing intact.

NEW SQUAD TYPE - DESPOILERS

Oct 26, 2025

The Despoilers are forged in centuries of blood-feuds, death-hunts, and planetary collapse. Violent killers who revel in terror, trophy-taking, and the destruction of symbols.

NEW SQUAD TYPE - PRAXIUM CORPS

Oct 20, 2025

The Praxium Corps are the apex of Hegemony martial doctrine. Few in number, absolute in purpose. Each Unit is the living embodiment of a perfected combat philosophy, a human doctrine rendered in flesh and steel.